negotiations. For this, it was necessary that the Akalis didn't lose faith in the process. Second, care had to be taken that Bhindranwale did not go too fast and too far in his extremist activities, which could force the government to intervene much before the predetermined time.

The 1 Akbar Road group had enough time to place their own trusted men in the Bhindranwale circle to win the confidence of Bhindranwale and influence his decisions. This they did either through party workers or through intelligence agencies. Harminder Singh Sandhu, general secretary of the AISSF, was suspected to be one such person. [5] As Harminder knew English well, Bhindranwale used him as an interpreter whenever an English-speaking visitor came to meet him. Sandhu was also suspected to be an agent run by the R&AW for intelligence on Bhindranwale and on Pakistan's involvement in Punjab-related violence (though not to my knowledge). Incidentally, Sandhu was the only one among Bhindranwale's inner circle who surrendered to the army during Operation Blue Star. There might have been many more such moles, especially among those who escaped from the Akal Takht/Golden Temple complex on the eve of Operation Blue Star.

During that period I had heard of one such person (name withheld, as desired by the source of information) who won Bhindranwale's trust by presenting him with a brand-new revolver, which he liked and asked for a second, which was promptly procured and presented, courtesy of one of the two intelligence agencies concerned. This man also escaped from the Golden Temple complex a few days before the army moved in.

Both these tasks had to be manged by the 1 Akbar Road group through their contacts or through reliable second-level Congress leaders and the three-man think-tank. The Akali Dal leaders could be manipulated through people like Balwant Singh (who was close to P.C. Alexander) and a couple of others who might have risen through the ranks of the Akali Dal or gained importance because of the support of persons or agencies of the Central government. For an informed reader it should not be difficult to shortlist the names of some such Akali Dal leaders.